

Capsule ➤ A spore-producing capsule forms at the tip of each threadlike sporophyte. When the spores are mature, the lid of the capsule breaks off to reveal an opening, through which the spores are released. Every capsule contains hundreds of thousands of tiny spores, which are carried off on the wind.

Capillary thread moss

Brown sporophytes do not make their own food, relying on the green gametophyte instead.

Nonflowering plants

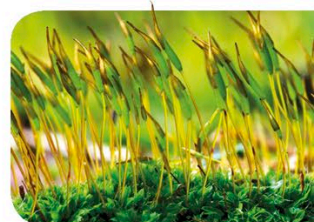
Liverwort

The first land plants were the tiny liverworts, which appeared around 470 million years ago. Around 9,000 liverwort species exist today.



Moss

Mosses grow in fluffy clumps, often in shady areas. Although they may look similar, 12,000 different types of mosses exist around the world.



Hornwort

These humidity-loving plants, which are named for their horn-shaped sporophytes, can even grow under water.



Club moss

The spore-producing brown spikes of club mosses are held on mosslike stems, but unlike mosses, the green parts are the sporophytes.



Horsetails

Horsetails have thin, hairlike leaves that run up their stems like a bottlebrush, and produce spores in conelike structures at the stem tip.



Sporophyte ➤ The spore-producing, columnlike structure rising from the green body of the moss is a sporophyte. It starts to grow when a female egg cell is fertilized by a male sperm cell.